THE BATTLE OF TSUSHIMA

In October 1904 five divisions of the Russian Baltic Fleet, renamed Second Pacific Squadron, set off on a journey of 18,000 nautical miles (30,000 km) to join the defense of Port Arthur against the Japanese. Commanded by Admiral Zinovi Rozhdestvenski, the squadron showed its inexperience by firing on British trawlers in the North Sea, taking them for Japanese torpedo boats. Slow and grueling, the long and difficult voyage took a heavy toll on the laboring ships' engines and on crew morale. Rozhdestvenski was joined by Admiral Nikolai Nebogatov with more Baltic warships, designated Third Pacific Squadron, to create a fleet of impressive size, but dubious quality.

Port Arthur had fallen by the time this Russian armada reached East Asia, so Vladivostok became its substitute goal. Short of coal, Rozhdestvenski chose the shortest route past Japan, through the Tsushima Strait. Admiral Heihachiro Togo, commanding the Japanese Combined Fleet, had anticipated this choice. But on the night of May 26-27, in fog and mist, the Russians might have slipped past had not the Japanese auxiliary cruiser *Shinano Maru* spotted a Russian hospital ship with its navigation lights lit. On board his flagship *Mikasa* in Chinae Bay, Admiral Togo was immediately informed by radio—then still a novel technology. Togo in turn informed his government: "The Russian fleet has been sighted. I will attack it and annihilate it." The admiral's confidence, shared by his officers and men, contrasted markedly with the state of mind of the Russians after their arduous journey. Togo's only fear was that the enemy fleet might escape in the mist and gloom. Once visual contact was made in the early afternoon, the Russians were doomed.

RELENTLESS PURSUIT

Togo was a great admirer of Nelson and, recognizing this as his Trafalgar, announced the start of the battle by hoisting the "Z" flag, conveying the signal: "The Empire's fate depends on the outcome of this battle, let every man do his utmost duty." Where the Russians had difficulty holding a line of battle in a chaos of confused orders and poor seamanship, the Japanese maneuvered with precision and daring, exploiting to the full their speed advantage over the Russian ships. In the gunnery duel between battleships the Japanese proved far superior, due to better training and range-finding technology. Their high-explosive shells devastated the superstructure of Russian ships, scattering deadly steel splinters, starting fires, and ripping open armor. A Russian officer described how "iron ladders were crumpled into rings and guns hurled from their mountings."

By nightfall four Russian battleships had been sunk, with appalling loss of life. Rozhdestvenski was wounded by a shell fragment in the skull, leaving the inexperienced Nebogatov in command. Through the night attacks by Japanese destroyers and torpedo boats took a further toll, and morning found scattered remnants of the Russian fleet struggling for survival. At 10:30 a.m. Nebogatov abjectly surrendered the ships under his immediate command. Other Russian warships were hunted down through the day. Only three made it through to Vladivostok.

The battle forced Russia to accept defeat in the war with Japan and led to the 1905 revolutionary uprising against the tsarist regime.

RUSSO-JAPANESE WAR



BATTLE OF TSUSHIMA

Date	May 27–28, 1905
Location	Tsushima Strait, between Japan and Korea
Result	Japanese victory

COMBATANTS

JAPAN	RUSSIA

COMMANDERS

Heihachiro Togo	Zinovi Rozhdestvenski Nikolai Nebogatov

FORCES

Ships: 4 battleships, 24 cruisers, 20 destroyers, 16 torpedo boats	**Ships:** 8 battleships, 8 cruisers, 3 coastal monitors, 9 destroyers

LOSSES

Men: 117 **Ships**: 3 torpedo boats sunk	**Men:** 4,380 killed, 5,917 captured **Ships:** 17 ships sunk, 5 captured

Prizes of war
Captured Russian warships, with the Japanese Rising Sun flying proudly over the Russian naval ensign, are towed back to Japan after the crushing Russian defeat at Tsushima.

